thousands of Muslims in Gujarat? There is plenty of evidence, direct as well as circumstantial, to connect leaders of our major political parties to these mass murders. But could we ever imagine any of them being arrested, imprisoned for eleven years, let alone executed? Oh no. On the contrary, one of them—who had never held public office—was recently given a state funeral that brought the city of Mumbai to a standstill. Another will most likely be running for the post of Prime Minister of the World's Largest Democracy in the next election.

In this cold, cowardly way, making empty, exaggerated gestures that mimic Due Process, India's own brand of fascism has laid itself upon us.

In the Mazar-e-Shohadda in Srinagar, the epitaph on Afzal's tombstone (which the police removed, and then was forced to replace because of public outrage) reads, in translation:

> The martyr of the nation, Shaheed Mohammad Afzal Guru, Date of Martyrdom: 9th February 2013 Saturday, whose mortal remains are lying in the custody of the Government of India. The nation is awaiting its return.

Knowing what we do, it would be hard to describe Afzal Guru as a warrior in any conventional sense of the word. His shahadat, his martyrdom, comes from having experienced and borne witness to the hell that tens of thousands of ordinary young Kashmiris have lived through. Like them, he has been burned, beaten, electrocuted, blackmailed and now killed. (You can read a description of what was done to him on one occasion, in the picturesque words of his torturer, in Appendix III.) But while Afzal Guru was executed in the greatest secrecy, the events that led to his execution were performed on stage to a full house. When the curtains went down and the lights came up, the audience applauded. The reviews were mixed, but what the hell, the deed had been done.

The 'full-truth' is that Afzal Guru is dead and that we will probably never know who attacked the Indian Parliament. The Bharatiya Janata Party has been robbed of its grisly election ditty: *'Desh abhi sharminda hai, Afzal abhi bhi zinda hai'* (The Nation is Still in Shame, Afzal is Still Alive). It will have to come up with a new one.

Long before he was arrested and jailed, Afzal Guru was a broken man. Now that he is dead, those who prey on carrion are circling over his body, trying to gain political traction, and to contain, co-opt and manage people's fury. For some time to come we will be presented with letters he never wrote,